

Feathers tended to get in the way, but were sometimes left on for show.

*"And then the whining schoolboy,
with his satchel, and shining morning
face, creeping like a snail
unwillingly to school."*

WILLIAM SHAKESPEARE
Jaques in *As You Like It*

The pen had to be dipped into the ink at regular intervals.

Horn
inkwells

PEN AND INK

Before children could begin learning to write, they had to make themselves a pen called a quill from a goose feather.

They trimmed the feather to the right shape and size using a "penknife," then cut the tip at an angle to make a point. Ink was kept in a pot called an inkwell, made of sheep's horn, wood, pottery, or metal.

BALANCING ACT

There were no desks in Tudor schools, so pupils had to rest their work on their knees. This was no problem when they were reading from textbooks and hornbooks, but it must have made things very difficult when they had to practice their handwriting! In the petty school, children sat on stools, but older schoolboys sat on long benches called forms.

A selection of goose feather quills



TRAGIC INSPIRATION

At school, Shakespeare was introduced to the work of ancient Roman authors such as Seneca (4 BC–65 AD). Seneca wrote serious plays called tragedies, which dealt with the suffering and death of great heroes. When Shakespeare grew up to be a writer, one of his first plays was a bloodthirsty tragedy inspired by Seneca called *Titus Andronicus*.



OLD FAVORITE

Shakespeare's favorite writer was the poet Ovid (43 BC–17 AD), whose poem *Metamorphoses* is a collection of stories drawn from ancient Greek and Roman myths. In 1598, a writer called Francis Meres compared Shakespeare to Ovid: "The sweet witty soul of Ovid lives in mellifluous and honey-tongued Shakespeare."

As he reads,
the schoolboy
follows the
words with
his finger.